



Research Program

Funding Guidelines

Document Control

Content Drafted	Heart Foundation Research Program Team
Scheduled reviews	Annually in November
Security classification	Public

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1. Introduction

The Heart Foundation Research Program is overseen by the Research Advisory Committee (RAC). The RAC is comprised of leading researchers and consumer representatives from across Australia with expertise in a broad range of cardiovascular health disciplines and experiences. The RAC provides expert advice on strategic research approaches and the Heart Foundation's research funding program. The RAC is responsible for reviewing the annual research funding allocation, ensuring research funding is awarded based on merit, potential impact, equity of distribution and relevance.

The Heart Foundation Research Program manages the Research Funding Portfolio. All communications relating to Heart Foundation research funding programs and Heart Foundation funded research projects should be directed to the Heart Foundation Research Program:

- **Email:** research@heartfoundation.org.au
- **Phone:** (03) 9321 1581

2. Standards for Research

2.1 Research Conduct

The Heart Foundation expects the highest standards of research integrity in all aspects of the research we support. Heart Foundation funded research must be conducted in accordance with the [Australian Code for the Responsible Conduct of Research, 2018](#).

We require all research proposals and Heart Foundation-funded research to comply with the guidelines listed below and all other relevant laws, regulations, guidelines and policies related to the conduct of research.

- [Guidance to support the Code](#)
- [National Statement on Ethical Conduct in Human Research 2023](#)
- [Ethical conduct in research with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Peoples and communities: Guidelines for researchers and stakeholders](#)
- [Australian Code for the care and use of animals for scientific purposes](#)

Compliance is the responsibility of researchers and Administering Institutions.

2.2 Clearance Requirements

Researchers awarded a Heart Foundation grant are required to obtain the necessary ethics and/or biosafety clearance/s before payments will commence. Any clearances required for a grant, as indicated in the application for funding, must be maintained by the Administering Institution for the complete duration of the grant, and a copy provided to the Heart Foundation on request. If clearances have not been obtained before payments are due to commence, the Administering Institution must advise the Heart Foundation.

The Heart Foundation will conduct random checks of the status of clearances by contacting the Administering Institution holding the grant.

2.3 Privacy Principles

In accordance with the Privacy Amendment (Private Sector) Act 2000 (Cth), individuals, investigators, or research institutions associated with all Heart Foundation grants must comply with the National Health and Medical Research Council (NHMRC) Guidelines as stipulated under [Section 95 of the Privacy Act 1988 \(Cth\)](#). This ensures the protection of personal information in the conduct of medical and health research, balancing privacy with the public interest in significant medical research. All applications for funding are treated with the utmost confidentiality. Access to these applications is strictly limited to designated assessors, review and interview committees, and essential Heart Foundation personnel to maintain the integrity and privacy of the submission process.

For further information regarding how we manage and protect your information, please refer to the Heart Foundation's Privacy Policy available on our [website](#). This document provides comprehensive details on our data handling practices, including collection, use, disclosure, and security of personal information.

2.4 Confidentiality and Commercial-in-Confidence

All submissions to the Heart Foundation are managed with strict confidentiality. Access is strictly limited to authorised assessors, review committees, and Heart Foundation personnel to safeguard the integrity of the application process.

The Heart Foundation acknowledges that certain applications may lead to commercial outcomes. In instances where including commercially sensitive information might compromise the Intellectual Property (IP) of the project, applicants are encouraged to provide a balanced overview. This overview must detail enough scientific rationale and underlying principles of the proposed research to allow for thorough peer review and evaluation, while safeguarding sensitive commercial information.

2.5 Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence

Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in the preparation of grant applications

Permitted Uses of AI Tools

Non-Generative AI Tools

Applicants may use non-generative tools such as grammar checkers, spell checkers, and style editors.

Generative AI

Generative AI tools, including large language models (e.g. ChatGPT, Claude, Claude, Gemini, Copilot) may only be used to assist with administrative tasks or to edit content in the preparation of grant applications.

Declaration and Accountability

Applicants and institutions must declare any use of AI in preparation of the grant application at the time of submission. All information provided must be certified as accurate, with applicants and institutions remaining fully accountable for the submitted content. Disclosure of AI use will not influence review outcomes.

Applications found to contain verified hallucinations, misinformation, or obvious AI-generated errors will be deemed ineligible and removed from the review process.

Compliance and Consequences

Failure to accurately disclose AI use, if subsequently identified, may result in the proposal being deemed ineligible and withdrawn from the review process.

Reviewers engaged in the evaluation of applications are strictly prohibited from using any form of generative AI tooling to assist in their review process. This restriction is critical to maintaining the confidentiality and integrity of all submitted applications.

4. Funding Rules

For applications to be considered for the Heart Foundation Research Funding programs described in these guidelines (Future Leader Fellowships, Postdoctoral Fellowships, Postgraduate Scholarships, First Nations CVD Grants, Vanguard Grants and Collaboration and Exchange Grants), the following criteria apply:

- Funding is available to those conducting cardiovascular research (including stroke research).
- Applications must be submitted via the Heart Foundation's [Grants Management Portal](#) by an NHMRC Administering Institution.
- The Chief Investigator A (CIA) must be affiliated with an NHMRC Administering Institution.
- The CIA and their Administering Institution must ensure that applications meet all eligibility requirements as set out in these Funding Guidelines. Applications that do not meet these requirements may be deemed ineligible and eliminated from consideration.
- Projects may be pursued in Biomedical, Clinical, Public Health and Health Services research if relevant to cardiovascular health and disease.
- The Heart Foundation requires Administering Institutions to have appropriate policies and procedures in place to deal with any allegations of research misconduct that may arise.
- The Administering Institution (or its affiliate) shall provide the facilities and services necessary for the efficient conduct of research during the term of a grant.
- Funding will commence from 1 January, 1 April or 1 July of the year following the application submission.
- The individuals, research groups or research institutions associated with a Heart Foundation grant shall not accept any funds by way of research grants, consultancies or sponsorships from the Tobacco industry or persons connected with the Tobacco industry. This includes direct funding, as well as advertising, sponsorship, gifts or loan of goods or services, or funding by any other means.
 - Tobacco industry means any organisation or individual involved in the growth, preparation for sale, sale, shipping, advertising and distribution of tobacco and tobacco-related products, including but not limited to cigarettes, cigars, loose tobacco and e-cigarettes.
- Employees of the Heart Foundation are not eligible to apply for funding.

Each research funding program has its own set of eligibility criteria, which are listed on the following pages.

4.1 Career Disruption and Relative to Opportunity

The Heart Foundation recognises that all research careers are not the same. Our peer reviewers assess track records relative to opportunity; that is, they take into consideration whether an applicant's research productivity and contributions are consistent with the opportunities available to them at their career stage. In determining the eligibility of an application for a particular funding program, only Career Disruption is taken into account and not Relative to Opportunity.

Career Disruption refers to a prolonged interruption of at least 28 continuous days to an individual's ability to work due to:

- pregnancy
- major illness or injury
- carer responsibilities, including parental leave.

The following are not considered career disruptions:

- employment outside the research sector (e.g. time spent working in industry)
- clinical, administrative, or teaching workload
- relocation of laboratory or clinical practice setting
- other similar circumstances that impact research productivity but do not meet the criteria above

Eligibility Requirements for Career Disruption Claims

To be considered eligible, career disruptions must meet the following conditions:

1. Timing

- Absences must occur after the award of the PhD

2. Minimum Duration

- Disruptions must be at least 28 continuous days (this includes weekends)
- Individual days or multiple shorter absences (e.g. several periods of 1–27 days) cannot be combined to meet the threshold

3. Exclusions

- Annual personal leave and short-term sick leave cannot be included.
- Absences related to the conduct of research (e.g. attending conferences, training, sabbaticals, lab placements, or study directly related to research) cannot be included.

4. Fractional work

- Fractional work (i.e. reduced FTE due to circumstances classified as a career disruption) is not subject to the 28-day rule and can be included

5. Application Use

- For grant eligibility, all eligible career disruptions post-PhD will be included
- For track record extension, only eligible career disruptions within the specified track record period will be included (e.g. for a Future Leader Fellowship, only absences within the past 10 years are eligible)

Relative to Opportunity includes career disruptions as well as other personal or professional circumstances affecting research output.

When providing details of other Relative to Opportunity considerations, an applicant may include any circumstances that they believe have impacted their research output. These circumstances may include key appointments, career disruption/s, and/or their active time conducting cardiovascular research. Disruptions to careers and research projects relating to major events, such as the COVID-19 pandemic, may be included under Relative to Opportunity.

4.2 Multiple Fellowships, Scholarships or Other Salary Support

The recipient of a Heart Foundation Postdoctoral Fellowship or Future Leader Fellowship is not entitled to concurrently receive salary support funding from another grant, fellowship or an NHMRC Investigator Grant.

If an applicant is successful with an application to the Heart Foundation Future Leader Fellowship or Postdoctoral Fellowship program as well as a third-party funding program, the applicant will need to choose their salary funding provider. If the third party is chosen, the Heart Foundation may consider offering an Honorary Fellowship.

In limited circumstances, if the current holder of a Heart Foundation Postdoctoral Fellowship or Future Leader Fellowship is successful with an application for an NHMRC Investigator Grant, they may be permitted to continue to receive salary support funding from the Heart Foundation fellowship while receiving research support funding from the NHMRC Investigator Grant for the period the funding overlaps.

A recipient of a Heart Foundation Postgraduate Scholarship is not entitled to concurrently hold more than one postgraduate scholarship. Top-Up funding may be offered to an applicant who is successful at securing an NHMRC Postgraduate Scholarship, provided both scholarships have the same commencement date. Top-Up funding will be pro rata to account for any study already completed and will end on the same date as the NHMRC postgraduate Scholarship.

The Heart Foundation does not currently have any agreements in place to partner with third-party funding providers.

4.3 Major Events

The Heart Foundation acknowledges that major national and world-wide events could disrupt the way we work. We will consider the impact of major events, such as natural disasters or world-wide pandemics, on the health and medical research sector. Factors taken into account may include the ability of researchers to submit applications and undertake their research. In some cases, application closing dates may be extended or grant extension or Leave of Absence requests may be approved.

5. Consumers in Research

The Heart Foundation embraces the view that greater consumer involvement allows health-services professionals to plan more confidently, develop more robust policies, and deliver their services more effectively.

Research efforts find their fullest expression in the advancement of health care for all Australians, and only with the participation of consumers can we ensure that both the questions we ask and the answers we pursue are rooted in the most beneficial context possible. Involving consumers throughout the research process is a critical component of the research process.

The Research Program's [*Consumer Guide for Researchers*](#) covers the involvement of consumers in your research and includes:

- elements of consumer involvement
- why consumer involvement is important
- levels of consumer involvement
- considerations for researchers
- best practices for consumer involvement
- research cycle

Check with the Research Office at your Administering Institution if your institution has consumer groups you could reach out to.

Co-design and consultation from the planning stages are preferable for consumer engagement.

6. Applying for Funding

Applications for Heart Foundation Research Funding opportunities included in these Funding Guidelines are to be submitted via the Heart Foundation [Grants Management Portal](#) by the specified deadline.

Application opening and closing dates are published on the [Heart Foundation website](#).

Before commencing an application for funding, applicants must read the applicable funding program guidelines.

It is the responsibility of the applicant and the Administering Institution's RAO to ensure that the application is complete, accurate, and meets the applicable eligibility criteria.

Application questions will be made available from the funding program opening date. From the funding program opening date researchers will be able to start completing an application. Instructions are provided within the [Grants Management Portal](#) at each step to clarify the information required.

The CIA must submit their application to their RAO for endorsement. The RAO will submit the application to the Heart Foundation. The endorsement process is managed through the [Grants Management Portal](#).

No changes can be made to applications after submission to the Heart Foundation.

6.1 Integration with ORCID

Integration with ORCID (Open Researcher and Contributor ID) is a key feature of the Heart Foundation's [Grants Management Portal](#) that allows track record information to be imported from researchers' ORCID records to be used in their grant applications and progress/impact reports.

Completing an applicant's track record information will require them to register for an ORCID ID and create or update their ORCID record.

The following table explains which sections of ORCID must be populated to complete the corresponding track record questions in relevant applications. A guide with additional detail is available on the [Heart Foundation website](#).

Heart Foundation Application - Track Record	ORCID Record Category
Applicant Work History	Employment
Qualifications	Education & Qualifications
Publications	Works
Presentations	Works
Awards & Distinctions	Professional Activities

The Heart Foundation accepts the following types of publications: Accepted for Publication; Books/Chapters; Editorials; Journal Articles (Original Research); Journal Articles (Review); Letters to the Editor; Research Reports – commissioned by Government, Industry or Other; Technical Reports; Policy Briefs and Text Books.

Publications and other research outputs can continue to be updated in ORCID for use in future applications but these updates will not appear in submitted applications. Only the ORCID details at time of application submission will be associated with that application. Hyperlinks should not be included in any part of an application.

[NHMRC and ARC Statement on Open Researcher and Contributor ID \(ORCID\)](#)

6.2 Research Plan Templates

A Word template for each funding program will be available for applicants to provide their Research Plans and Figures. These templates will be available in the [Grants Management Portal](#) and on the webpage for each funding program, accessible from [Applying for research funding with the Heart Foundation](#).

Applicants **must** use the provided template and upload the document into their application in the [Grants Management Portal](#) saved as a PDF file no larger than **5MB**. Applications that fail to comply with the formatting requirements below may be excluded from consideration.

6.2.1 File naming and formatting requirements:

- CIA name and application ID in header
- Font: 12pt Arial
- Line spacing: single
- Page margins: 2cm top, bottom, left, right
- Page size: A4
- Page numbers in footer
- PDF file name format: **Application ID_CIA surname_Research_Plan.pdf**

6.2.2 Research Plan components:

Funding Program	A. Research Plan Description	B. Project Milestones	C. References
Future Leader Fellowship	Up to 6 pages	Table provided	15 references
Postdoctoral Fellowship	Up to 4 pages	Table provided	15 references
Vanguard Grant	Up to 4 pages	Table provided	15 references
First Nations CVD Grant	Up to 4 pages	Table provided	15 references
Postgraduate Scholarship	Up to 4 pages	Table provided	15 references

A maximum of 3 images/figures may be included in the Research Plan.

The Research Plan Description should comprise the Aims, Background, and Methods of the proposed research project. Further details will be available in the [Grants Management Portal](#).

Project Milestones and References are additional to the pages allocated to the Research Plan Description.

Expected outcomes are to be provided elsewhere in the application.

6.3 Submission Deadlines

Applications must be received by the Heart Foundation by no later than 5.00 pm AEST or AEDT (where applicable) on the funding program deadline date. It will not be possible to submit a late application.

Extensions to submission deadlines will be granted only in extreme circumstances, including but not limited to:

- Major events - natural disasters or major pandemics
- Major illness of the applicant
- Heart Foundation related IT disruptions causing the [Grants Management Portal](#) to be non-operational.

Any request for an extension must be made by the Administering Institution prior to the submission deadline.

6.4 Assistance with Applications

Applicants requiring assistance should direct queries to their Administering Institution's RAO. RAOs can contact the Heart Foundation Research Program for further advice:

- **Email:** research@heartfoundation.org.au
- **Phone:** (03) 9321 1581

7. Future Leader Fellowship

The Future Leader Fellowship program aims to support the best and brightest in cardiovascular research. It supports aspiring leaders who are developing independence and their own research portfolio, through to established leaders of cardiovascular research groups with extensive research programs.

7.1 Eligibility Criteria

For applications to be considered for funding, the following criteria apply:

- The application must be submitted via the Heart Foundation [Grants Management Portal](#).
- The applicant will be considered the Chief Investigator A (CIA) on the proposed project.
- CIA must be an Australian or New Zealand citizen, an Australian permanent resident, or have applied for Australian permanent residency at the stage 1 application closing date.
- CIA must be involved in cardiovascular research (including stroke research).
- Applicants are expected to have at least two years of research experience relevant to the context of the grant.
- CIA must be from an NHMRC Administering Institution.
- CIA must be based in Australia for at least 80% of the funding period.
- Applicants may choose to apply at one of three levels:
 - **Level 1** applicants to be a minimum of **three** years and less than **seven** years post PhD pass date prior to the stage 1 application closing date.
 - **Level 2** applicants to be a minimum of **seven** years and less than **ten** years post PhD pass date prior to the stage 1 application closing date.
 - **Level 3** applicants to be a minimum of **ten** years and less than **fifteen** years post PhD pass date prior to the stage 1 application closing date.
 - The PhD pass date is the date of the letter advising that the PhD was passed. It is not the conferral date.
 - Applicants may apply at a level lower than they are eligible for based on the number of years since their PhD pass date if they can demonstrate that their 'effective' number of years since their PhD pass date falls within the eligibility range once Career Disruptions are considered (**not** other Relative to Opportunity factors).
 - Applicants may apply at a level higher than they are eligible for based on the number of years since their PhD pass date; however, applications will only be considered in the requested category. This does not apply to Level 1; applicants less than 3 years post PhD pass date cannot apply under this rule.
 - Applicants should refer to the Indicative Criteria for the expectation of performance at each of the levels.
 - Applicants may apply to progress through the Future Leader Fellowship levels; however, they cannot receive the same level twice.
 - Applicants may apply to undertake the Future Leader Fellowship between 0.6 FTE and 1.0 FTE.
- Applicants may apply for only one Heart Foundation Fellowship category or type (including Heart Foundation Postdoctoral Fellowships) in any year. Should an applicant apply for

multiple Fellowship categories or types, all applications from that applicant will be removed from further consideration.

- A successful applicant may not concurrently receive salary support funding from another fellowship or an NHMRC Investigator Grant (refer to section 4.2 of these guidelines for more information).
 - Should an applicant be successful with applications to both the Heart Foundation Future Leader Fellowship program and a third-party funding program, the applicant will need to choose their funding provider. If the third party is chosen, the Heart Foundation may consider offering an Honorary Fellowship.

7.2 Funding Amount and Duration

Full time Future Leader Fellowships are funded for four years, with salary support and project support at the levels specified below. The salary support component will be adjusted pro rata for part time fellowships (minimum 0.6FTE).

	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Project support	\$40,000 p.a.	\$50,000 p.a.	\$50,000 p.a.
Salary support – Year 1	\$90,000	\$110,000	\$120,000
Salary support – Year 2	\$91,500	\$112,000	\$122,000
Salary support – Year 3	\$93,000	\$114,000	\$124,000
Salary support – Year 4	\$94,500	\$116,000	\$126,000

The Salary support component is provided to assist in employing the fellowship recipient.

The Project support component is to be spent on other research costs (refer to 14. Application Budgets for information on allowable and prohibited costs). A budget for the project support component must be completed in the application.

7.3 Specific Considerations

If successful in obtaining funding, please note the special considerations set out in Annexure B of the Funding Agreement. These are to be considered in conjunction with the terms and conditions set out within the Heart Foundation Funding Agreement.

- Grantees shall spend a minimum of 80% of their FTE time on research.
- Grantees are expected to devote the FTE specified in their application research plan to the grant activity, which must not be less than 0.6 FTE.
- Participation in teaching and attendance at advanced courses relevant to the grant activity may be permitted by the Heart Foundation if participation occupies only a small proportion of the Grantee's FTE.
- The private practice of medicine and routine clinical or administrative duties are not compatible with the full-time Future Leader Fellowship. Full-time Fellows may spend no more than 20% of their FTE performing routine clinical duties or teaching. Part-time Fellows may spend their non-research FTE performing routine clinical duties or teaching.
- Grantees may not receive regular remuneration or grants that contain additional salary support in addition to the Fellowship except with prior approval from the Heart Foundation.
- A grantee proposing to accept a substantive paid appointment will normally be required to relinquish their fellowship. In such cases, the grantee shall advise the Heart Foundation in writing and in advance.

- Full-time grantees may apply to reduce their FTE for personal reasons such as carer responsibilities, but not for vocational reasons such as wishing to work part-time. Requests to reduce a full-time grant to part time will be assessed on a case-by-case basis. If approved, the grant will be extended pro-rata to account for the change in FTE.
- The Heart Foundation is to be notified immediately via a Variation Request if the grantee's employment circumstances change during the tenure of a fellowship, particularly when the ability of the grantee to undertake the grant activities may be affected by the change in circumstances. The Variation Request must detail any financial and/or administrative implications for the grantee, as well as any implications of the change on their ability to undertake the roles and responsibilities associated with the grant.

7.4 Indicative Criteria

Throughout all stages of the peer review process, assessment is based on the below **Indicative Criteria** for a Future Leader Fellow relative to opportunity.

	FLF: Level 1 <i>3 years & less than 7 years post PhD</i> <i>Relative to opportunity</i>	FLF: Level 2 <i>7 years & less than 10 years post PhD</i> <i>Relative to opportunity</i>	FLF: Level 3 <i>10 years & less than 15 years post PhD</i> <i>Relative to opportunity</i>
Leadership, mentoring and training	• beginning to gain recognition for their expertise in their research area • demonstrate commitment to cardiovascular research • original contribution(s) in their field of expertise • ability to contribute to the conception of research projects • works within a larger team under the mentorship of more senior researchers • limited but developing supervision of research staff and Honours and PhD students • beginning to build their own team	• recognised for their expertise in their research area • demonstrate commitment to cardiovascular research • leading own research projects • original contributions of influence in their field of expertise • ability to contribute to the conception and direction of research projects, while developing independence • works within a larger team under the mentorship of more senior researchers • supervise PhD students • experience in supervising a small research team • building a team and mentoring ECRs / MCRs	• recognised as a national authority in their research area • demonstrate commitment to cardiovascular research • original contributions that are of major benefit to health and medical research, the health system, economy and/or the health of the population • independently leading and directing research projects • have established a team that is achieving independent outcomes • supervise PhD students • supervision, mentoring and promotion of early and mid-career researchers • demonstrated success as a mentor of emerging and future research leaders
Publication Record	• producing quality, cited publications in high-ranking journals with the majority being cardiovascular research publications • producing medium to high impact publications	• establishing a strong track record in their field through highly cited publications in high-ranking journals with the majority being cardiovascular research publications	• high publication output to a level eligible to lead Category 1 grants • high impact publications with the majority being cardiovascular research publications

	producing several publications as first author	- producing several publications as first author but also moving to senior author position - input into reports to government and/or other organisations - input into translational documents such as guidelines	- producing a considerable number of publications as senior author - may be producing reports to government and/or other organisations - may be producing translational documents such as guidelines
Presentation Record	successful abstract and poster invitations to present at national or international conferences	invited presentations and invitations to present at national or international conferences	keynote invitations and Orations to present at national or international conferences, including several invited presentations
Grant Record	CI on successful applications to national and/or international competitive funding programs or CIA on local grants	CIA on successful applications to national and/or international competitive funding programs	CIA on successful applications to national and/or international competitive funding programs
Scientific Community Contribution	- scientific contributions within their region, state, or territory (e.g., community leadership, state level contribution to a professional society) - contributions within their department, centre, institution, or organisation e.g., organising journal clubs, seminar series etc.	- national contributions to their scientific discipline (e.g., public advocacy, community leadership, peer review and professional societies) - contributions within their department, centre, institution, or organisation e.g., organising journal clubs, seminar series etc.	- national contributions to their scientific discipline (e.g., public advocacy, peer review, research advisory boards or professional societies) - contribution(s) within their department, centre, institution, or organisation that extend beyond their research e.g., membership of regulatory or management committees
The research proposal should: - be of outstanding design with negligible weakness - be feasible and almost certain to be achieved within the term of the fellowship - make an outstanding case for the research to be important in addressing a cardiovascular health issue - achieve integrated translational outcomes			
The research environment: - is very well matched to the applicant's proposed project - includes remarkably high quality administrative and technical support systems for the applicant - offers outstanding collaborative and mentoring opportunities for the applicant - offers outstanding potential for team building for the applicant			

7.5 Application Assessment

At each review stage, applications will be assessed on the extent to which they address the assessment criteria. Reviewers will provide a score for each criterion using the seven-point scale and associated score descriptors designated in the Peer Review Guide. Depending on the review type (peer or consumer) the same application question may be reviewed against different criteria

and may form part of the review for more than one criterion. Refer to the tables summarizing the questions and review stage for further details.

An overall score for each application will be determined using each reviewer's score for each assessment criterion. The overall score will take the weighting of each criterion into account. A ranked list of applications will be created.

All applications will be reviewed at Stage 1. The highest ranked applicants will be invited to proceed to the second application stage (Stage 2), where they will complete the full application. Those applicants ranked highest after stage 2 review will be invited to attend an interview (Stage 3).

Reviewers will consider Career Disruption/s and Relative to Opportunity when assessing track record.

7.5.1 Stage 1 Review: Review of the Executive Summary (Leadership Potential)

Each application will be reviewed by up to five peer reviewers.

ASSESSMENT CRITERIA

Executive Summary: Leadership Potential

This is the only assessment criterion in the first stage of review

In the Executive Summary, applicants are expected to provide a concise overview of the trajectory of their career, leadership and proposed project. This overview should give reviewers a full understanding of their leadership potential and/or experience and how that experience will achieve the outcomes in the proposed research plan. Reviewers will consider whether the applicant has the skill base, support, environment and team to achieve their proposed research plan.

Reviewers will refer to the Indicative Criteria as well as the application questions as indicated in the table below when assessing this criterion. Note that this criterion is only assessed by peer reviewers.

Criteria	Peer Stage 1	Peer Stage 2	Consumer
Leadership potential <i>Weighting</i>	100%		
Leadership summary	✓		
Research team	✓		
Project overview	✓		
Research environment	✓		
Post-Fellowship plans	✓		
Translation & dissemination	✓		
Track record:	✓		
1. Applicant's work history	✓		
2. Qualifications	✓		
3. Publications	✓		
4. Presentations	✓		
5. Awards and distinctions	✓		
6. Grant record	✓		

Track record data (ORCID data) will be included in Stage 1 review in the form of a summary table only. Justifications for track record selections will form part of the Stage 2 application. Applicants

who are invited to submit a Stage 2 application will also be able to provide an update to their track record with their Stage 2 application.

When selecting items for their track record, the applicant should include their most impactful, high-quality publications, presentations, and awards, and demonstrate their ability to attract funding.

7.5.2 Stage 2 Review: Detailed review of the full application

Applicants must be invited to progress to Stage 2 Review. Each application will be reviewed by up to five peer reviewers and two consumer reviewers.

ASSESSMENT CRITERIA

Person: Track Record

To assess the career of a researcher, reviewers look at what the applicant has achieved to date in their career, taking into consideration any career disruptions.

In relation to track record, the applicant should include their most impactful, high-quality publications, presentations, and awards, and demonstrate their ability to attract funding.

Reviewers will also consider where the proposed piece of research is expected to take the applicant in their career, as well as their post fellowship career plans.

As this fellowship is focused on leadership, it is important that the applicant can demonstrate their ability to work in and/or establish a competitive research team, along with how they plan to continue to build their team's capacity.

A high scoring applicant will be able to show the impact of their career to date, have a clear career path planned and clearly articulate their ability to develop their team.

Reviewers will refer to the Indicative Criteria as well as the application questions as indicated in the tables below when assessing this criterion.

Criterion	Peer Stage 1	Peer Stage 2	Consumer
Fellowship potential <i>Weighting</i>			40%
Leadership summary			✓
Post-Fellowship plans			✓

Criterion	Peer Stage 1	Peer Stage 2	Consumer
Track record <i>Weighting</i>		50%	
Training contribution		✓	
Scientific community contribution		✓	
Track record:		✓	
1. Applicant's work history		✓	
2. Qualifications		✓	
3. Publications		✓	
a. Justification - Publications		✓	
4. Presentations		✓	
a. Justification – Presentations		✓	
5. Awards and distinctions		✓	

a. Justification - Awards and distinctions		✓	
6. Grant record		✓	
Leadership summary		✓	
Research team		✓	
Post-Fellowship plans		✓	

Project: Quality and Feasibility of Research Proposal

The Heart Foundation is looking to support cardiovascular research projects where the application is well written, clear, and concise, the methodology is logical and well explained, the budget is well justified, and the expected outcomes are realistic and impactful.

Reviewers will assess the quality of the environment in which the research will be undertaken, the quality of the project and how achievable it is in the prescribed timeframe. The applicant must be able to show how they will deliver this project with the budget provided and it should be feasible and almost certain to be achieved within the term of the fellowship. If the project is beyond the scope of funding, the applicant should be able to identify other funding streams that will support the work.

While previous Heart Foundation funding is not required to progress through fellowship levels, consideration may be given where it is clearly articulated that the proposed project builds upon a previous project where important cardiovascular outcomes were achieved.

The research environment should be very well matched with the applicant's proposed project and include remarkably high quality administrative and technical support systems for the project.

A high scoring application will provide a clear and concise design with negligible weakness and make an outstanding case that the project is fresh, innovative and, most importantly, addressing a gap or major issue in cardiovascular health.

Reviewers will refer to the application questions as indicated in the table below when assessing this criterion.

Criterion	Peer Stage 1	Peer Stage 2	Consumer
Quality and feasibility of research proposal <i>Weighting</i>		25%	
Project overview		✓	
Research environment		✓	
Research plan and figures:		✓	
1. Background		✓	
2. Method		✓	
3. Project milestones		✓	
4. References		✓	
Expected outcomes		✓	
Budget		✓	
Previous funding		✓	

Significance and Potential Impact of the research

The Heart Foundation is looking to support high-impact cardiovascular research that is likely to produce results that will bring about significant change.

Consumer engagement and health equity requirements have been introduced into applications as end users of research need to be considered from the first to the last step. When assessing applications, reviewers will consider what a consumer is (patients, doctors, nurses, carers, those with lived experience or the public) to understand the need for all proposals to address consumer engagement in a meaningful way. It is important to note that not all proposals will be able to address all health equity areas but it is important for the applicant to explain why or why they are not addressing these areas. The proposal should demonstrate how the applicant plans to integrate translational outcomes, what happens once they have completed this funding, how the outcomes will be disseminated to consumers or the end user, and how they will lead to widespread improvements in cardiovascular health practices.

Reviewers will refer to the application questions as indicated in the tables below when assessing this criterion.

Criterion	Peer Stage 1	Peer Stage 2	Consumer
Significance and potential impact of the research <i>Weighting</i>		25%	
Consumer engagement		✓	
Promoting health equity:		✓	
1. Socioeconomically disadvantaged		✓	
2. Regional, rural and remote		✓	
3. Culturally and linguistically diverse		✓	
4. First Nations Peoples		✓	
5. Gender		✓	
Translation and dissemination		✓	

Criterion	Peer Stage 1	Peer Stage 2	Consumer
Potential impact of the research <i>Weighting</i>			60%
Project synopsis			✓
Research environment			✓
Expected outcomes			✓
Consumer engagement			✓
Promoting health equity:			✓
1. Socioeconomically disadvantaged			✓
2. Regional, rural and remote			✓
3. Culturally and linguistically diverse			✓
4. First Nations Peoples			✓
5. Gender			✓
Translation and dissemination			✓

7.5.3 Stage 3 Review: The Interview

Applicants who have progressed to Stage 3 will be interviewed by the peer and consumer review committees who will all score the applicant.

Interviews will be held over three days via a video platform, on **Tuesday 15 (Level 1), Wednesday 16 (Level 2) and Thursday 17 (Level 3) September 2026**.

INTERVIEW STRUCTURE

- Applicants will be invited to give a **brief** overview of their application.
- The Primary Spokesperson will ask three standard questions and two exploratory questions.
- The interview will be open to the committee to ask two additional questions.

ASSESSMENT CRITERIA

People

Accounts for 70% of score

Within the interview, the applicant should be able to answer all questions in a concise and informative manner. Within their responses they should focus on their ability as a leader in their field and how they can leverage that role to build their team through mentoring and training. The applicant should be able to talk to their track record achievements as well as their contribution to the cardiovascular/scientific community.

Project

Accounts for 30% of score

In the interview, the applicant should be able to express extensive knowledge of their project and the impact they hope to achieve. Not only should they be able to discuss their methodology but also demonstrate how they plan to integrate translational outcomes, what happens once they have completed this funding, how the findings will be disseminated to consumers or the end user, and how the outcomes will lead to widespread improvements in cardiovascular health practices.

13. Peer Review Committees

The Heart Foundation employs a rigorous, transparent, and independent peer and consumer review process to assist in the selection of applications for research funding. Only eligible and complete applications will proceed to review. Reviewers consider Career Disruption/s and Relative to Opportunity when assessing an applicant's track record.

It is not appropriate for applicants or Administering Institutions to contact any of our reviewers to discuss assessment results or seek further feedback. Should this occur, applicants or Administering Institutions may be deemed ineligible for future applications.

Where possible, the Heart Foundation provides reviewer feedback on applications.

13.1 Committees

A review committee is established for each funding program. For stage 1 reviews, the committees are made up of peer experts only, selected from the peer assessors for the program. For stage 2 reviews (Postgraduate Scholarships, Postdoctoral and Future Leader Fellowships, Vanguard Grants), committees include both peers and consumer representatives. For programs with a single-stage review (First Nations CVD Grant), both peers and consumers participate, whereas the Collaboration & Exchange program involves only peers.

Peer reviewers are selected from researchers who have demonstrated specialised knowledge in their area covering biomedical, clinical, public health, and health services research. For each funding program, committees are created by drawing from this group of reviewers. Attention is given to ensure as far as possible that each committee reflects diversity, striving for a balanced representation of genders, participants from different Australian states and territories, and a variety of professional backgrounds.

Each review committee is led by a Chair, who oversees the entire assessment process. While the Chair may assess applications, their main role is to act as a neutral party and resolve any ties in application scores.

Consumers are involved in assessing only the second stage of an application, except in single-stage reviews like the First Nations CVD Grant, where they assess that stage. Consumer reviewers are volunteers and may include consumer representatives, patients, carers, health professionals, people with lived experience, and members of the broader community with an interest in heart disease.

In every stage of the assessment process, confidentiality is of the utmost importance. The integrity and discretion of reviewers is trusted to protect the confidential nature of all applications, not only concerning the contents of the applications but also the assessments. Peer reviewers will:

- comply with the [Australian Code for the Responsible Conduct of Research \(2018\)](#)
- comply with the [Heart Foundation's privacy policy](#)
- be fair and timely in their reviews
- act in confidence and not disclose the content or outcome of any process in which they participate
- not enter any part of an application, or any information from an application, into an artificial intelligence / machine learning / natural language processing tool to assist in their assessment of an application
- ensure that they are informed about, and comply with, the criteria to be applied
- not take undue or calculated advantage of knowledge obtained during the peer review process

- declare all Conflicts of Interest (COI)
- not permit personal prejudice to influence the peer review process and will not introduce considerations that are not relevant to the review criteria
- be aware of and avoid allowing their conscious or unconscious biases to influence their assessments
- consider research that challenges, or changes accepted ways of thinking
- consider their expert knowledge of their field of research

Any information or documents made available to Committee members during peer review are confidential and will not be used for any purpose other than to fulfil their assessor role.

13.2 Conflicts of Interest

Before the commencement of any peer or consumer reviews, each member of our committees must complete a COI declaration in the [Grants Management Portal](#). At any time throughout the process, a committee member can update their COI declaration.

13.2.1 Peer Reviewers

Conflict Levels and Management Actions

Level	Examples of Conflict	Required Action	Additional Detail
Level 1: High Risk	• Direct collaboration with applicant/applicant supervisor • Co-authors of co-grant applicants (within last 5 years) • Proposed future co-authorship or grant application • Current or previous supervisor or mentor of applicant • Current personal relationship (applicant, family, close friend, partner, spouse) • Financial interest in outcome • Verbal or written dispute • Same institution in similar research area • Same department • Intellectual property interests	Must declare conflict Will not assess application	These conflicts present a clear and direct risk to impartiality. Reviewers will be excused from assessing application.
Level 2: Moderate Risk	• Collaboration in different area (within last 5 years) • Co-authors or co-grant applicants (over 5 years ago) • Close colleague collaboration (within last 5 years) • Same institution with knowledge of applicant/application/applicant supervisor • Professional relationship (within last 5 years) with family member, close friend, partner, spouse • Personal relationship (within last 5 years) with family member, close friend, partner, spouse • Consulting, or advisory roles	Must declare conflict Will not assess application	These conflicts may influence judgment and represent a potential risk. Reviewers will be excused from assessing application.

Level 3: Low Risk	• Collaboration in same area (over 5 years ago) • Same institution, no knowledge of applicant • Professional relationship (over 5 years ago) with family member, close friend, partner, spouse • Personal relationship (over 5 years ago) with family member, close friend, partner, spouse	Must declare conflict May assess application	These conflicts are historical or indirect. Disclosure is required, but exclusion is not mandatory unless further concerns arise.
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13.2.2 Consumer Reviewers

Level	Conflict	Action
Level 1: Highest level of conflict	Reviewer: – has a current personal relationship (family member, close friend, partner, or spouse) with an applicant, – has a financial interest in the outcome, – is a current work colleague, – is a current/Past consumer representative on the project.	Conflict must be declared, and the reviewer may not assess application nor be involved in any conversation regarding the application.
Level 2: Medium level of conflict	Reviewer: – is a previous work colleague, – has a personal relationship with the applicant in the last 10 years.	Conflict must be declared; however, the reviewer is still able to assess the application

13.3 Scoring System

The Heart Foundation uses a 1-7 scoring system in its review process.

At each review stage, reviewers assess the applications on the extent to which they address the assessment criteria. Reviewers provide a score for each criterion using the seven-point scale and associated score descriptors designated in the Reviewer Guide for the specific funding program. Reviewers will log into the [Grants Management Portal](#) to conduct their reviews.

An overall score for each application is determined using each reviewer's score for each criterion. The overall score will take the percentage weighting of each criterion into account. A ranked list of applications will be created and used to determine which applications proceed to the next stage of application (Future Leader Fellowships only), review or will be offered funding.

14. Application Budgets

14.1 Stipend/Salary Support

A stipend is a fixed regular sum paid as a salary or allowance. Stipend support is provided with Postgraduate Scholarship funding and must be allocated only to the salary of the scholar.

Salary support is provided with Future Leader Fellowships and Postdoctoral Fellowships to assist with their employment and must be allocated only to the salary of the Fellow.

Stipends and Salary support do not include Superannuation Guarantee, workers compensation, leave loading, payroll tax or other on costs.

14.2 Project Support

Project Support, provided with Future Leader Fellowships, Vanguard Grants and the First Nations CVD Grant, is to support the costs of conducting the proposed research. The costs must be directly related and integral to achieving the outcomes of the project. Project support funds cannot be used to supplement the salary of the CIA.

Project support funds **must not** be used for facility, administrative or other indirect costs that would be provided by the Administering Institution.

Two categories of Project support expenditure are available:

14.2.1 Personnel Costs

This category is for the cost of personnel required to conduct the project and may include but is not limited to: Project Manager/Officer, Site Coordinator, Research Coordinator / Assistant, Consumer Engagement, Information Technology support, Consultants, Data Analysis.

14.2.2 Other Research Costs

Other types of research costs may include but are not limited to (provided they are integral to the proposed research):

- Biomarkers
- Blood tests
- Genomic sequencing
- Specialised computer hardware or software
- Tablet computers
- Training equipment, materials, manuals and other training costs
- Data collection
- Data linkage
- Data storage
- Cost of interviews
- Participant reimbursement
- Laboratory consumables
- Animal costs
- Travel
- Ethics and/or governance fees
- Cost of advertisements
- Printing costs

14.2.3 Prohibited Costs

Project Support funds may **not** be used for the following types of expenditure:

1. salary for the applicant (CIA) or other Chief Investigators
2. stipend for a postgraduate student
3. administrative or employment costs and overheads

14.3 Collaboration and Exchange Grants

This grant is intended to support the travel of the recipient to conferences and /or exchange activities.

There are four budgetary options:

- Accommodation
- Flight
- Conference costs
- Other travel related costs

14.4 Innovation Awards

An Innovation Award provided by the Heart Foundation may be used to:

- support the salary of a person (other than the awardee) to conduct part of the grant activity
- pay for consumables to be used in connection with the grant activity
- for other related costs that have not been exclusively prohibited for the program that this award is connected to

An Innovation Award may not be used to:

- support the salary of the awardee or administrative costs
- support the stipend of a PhD or Master's Degree student

19. Obligations of Grant Recipients

Grant recipients play a crucial role in advancing cardiovascular health through research supported by the Heart Foundation. The Funding Agreement, specifically in section 16 “Acknowledgments and Publicity”, outlines the obligations of grant recipients, which are important for promoting the impact of research and maintaining the integrity and recognition of the Heart Foundation's contributions. Grant recipients are expected to contact the Research Program in advance of:

- publications going to press, and
- delivery of conference presentations (where possible)
- acknowledge the Heart Foundation in publications and presentations
- provide details of published papers to the Research Program
- participate in peer review of applications
- participate in Heart Foundation promotional initiatives

There are many opportunities to promote research at the Heart Foundation. To do this, we need the cooperation of researchers and institutions. This section elaborates on these obligations and the opportunities available for researchers to engage with and promote their work.

19.1 Your Researcher Profile

Upon accepting your funding offer, you will be invited to access an induction pack and to complete a Researcher Q&A in the [Grants Management Portal](#), including providing the Heart Foundation with a high-resolution portrait photograph. This information will assist the Heart Foundation in promoting the achievements of its Research Funding Program.

19.2 Media

The Heart Foundation has a reputation for providing reliable information on cardiovascular health and the media often approach us for stories or comments. Our media team will work collaboratively with researchers and institutions to promote research to the wider community.

If you have a publication due for release, please contact us at research@heartfoundation.org.au. The Heart Foundation Media and Communications team will help you assess whether your findings would be of interest to journalists and the wider community.

19.3 Social Media

The Heart Foundation has a strong social media following who love hearing about our funded research. Using social media is a terrific way to show off research and stay connected with fellow researchers. We ask researchers who receive funding to tag us in their posts.



[@heartfoundation](#)



[HeartFoundationAU](#)



[HeartFoundationAU](#)



[Heart Foundation](#) / [Heart Foundation Research Alumni](#)

Researchers can also forward any posts, messages, or content to research@heartfoundation.org.au and we will publish them as appropriate on our social media channels.

19.4 Publications and Presentations

The main purpose of Heart Foundation funding research is to have an impact on the cardiovascular health of all Australians. For that reason, grant recipients should advise the Heart Foundation of any publications or presentations relating to projects we are currently or have previously funded. Grantees must acknowledge the support of the Heart Foundation in any publication or presentation, public announcements, social media posting, advertising material, research reports or any other material relating to the funded research.

Examples of our preferred acknowledgment are in the format:

- [Title] [Surname] was supported by a [Grant Name, (Grant ID number)] from the National Heart Foundation of Australia.
- This work was supported by a [Grant Name (Grant ID number)] from the National Heart Foundation of Australia.

19.5 Logo Guidelines

When funded researchers are publishing a paper or doing a presentation, they can use the Heart Foundation logo to promote the funding connection. There are a variety of branding options available to best suit any collateral. Further details including correct use of the logo are available in the Researcher Induction Pack provided to all new grantees.

19.6 Campaigns and Appeals

To maintain research funding levels, the Heart Foundation relies on the generosity of donors. To keep them engaged, the Heart Foundation delivers annual marketing campaigns complemented by smaller more personalised donor appeals. All campaigns and appeals are themed and feature a case study matched with a piece of currently funded research. The Heart Foundation Research Program may reach out to researchers where there is an alignment to particular case studies.

19.7 Alumni

The Heart Foundation has a proud history of supporting outstanding researchers and we are delighted to be bringing together our previously funded researchers through our Alumni Program.

On conclusion of their funding, Heart Foundation grant recipients are automatically entered into our Alumni database. Heart Foundation Alumni may have access to additional exclusive webinars, events and newsletters. The Heart Foundation appreciates the length of time research takes to develop and achieve impact. Researchers are likely to publish future results based on work completed during the Heart Foundation funding period, and the Alumni program is a platform to continue active engagement with the Heart Foundation.

The Heart Foundation is committed to supporting and promoting the work of our grant recipients. By fulfilling these obligations and engaging with the provided opportunities, researchers can significantly contribute to the Heart Foundation's mission of improving cardiovascular health for all Australia.